

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: AFP

J.D. Vance said that **America** and **Iran** were close to a deal but that he did not know “when or if” Donald Trump would sign it. “A couple of language points” remained unresolved, according to America’s vice-president, including on nuclear enrichment. [The deal](#) would reportedly commit both sides to a 60-day ceasefire extension while they hold further discussions on Iran’s nuclear programme.

Binyamin Netanyahu said he directed **Israel’s** armed forces to seize at least 70% of **Gaza**. The prime minister’s order would violate a ceasefire agreement that America brokered in October, in which Israel agreed to leave just over half of the enclave occupied. Meanwhile, Israel continued striking southern **Lebanon**, despite a supposed ceasefire.

A **Russian drone** entered **Romania** and struck a block of flats in Galati, a city near the border with Ukraine, according to the Romanian defence ministry. The crash started a fire and injured two people. Several Russian drones have entered the NATO country’s airspace since the invasion of Ukraine in 2022. Ursula von der Leyen, the head of the European Commission, said Russia’s war has “crossed yet another line”.

Anthropic, an AI lab, secured \$65bn of funding at a valuation of \$900bn. It was valued at just \$380bn in February. Its estimated market worth is now higher than that of OpenAI, which was valued at \$852bn following a funding round that closed in April—a milestone which took around a decade to reach. Anthropic was founded only in 2021.

Japan's population fell by 3m between 2020 and 2025, the sharpest decline on record, according to preliminary census data. With 123m people, the country has returned to its population of the late 1980s. The country has [long struggled](#) with an ageing population and a declining birth rate.

Tilman Fertitta, a hospitality billionaire, agreed to buy **Caesars Entertainment**, a casino giant, in a deal worth \$17.6bn including debt. Mr Fertitta, an ally of Mr Trump, is America's ambassador to Italy. He owns Golden Nugget Hotels & Casinos, the Houston Rockets, a basketball team, and restaurant chains such as Rainforest Cafe and Morton's.

A New Glenn rocket made by **Blue Origin** exploded spectacularly on its launchpad in Florida. The firm was testing the vessel's engine; no one was harmed. After what he described as a “rough day”, Jeff Bezos, Blue Origin's owner, promised to “rebuild whatever needs rebuilding”. The firm is [struggling](#) to close the gap with SpaceX, its main competitor in the commercial spaceflight market.

Figure of the day: 65, the number of active state-based conflicts in 2025, the highest level since record-keeping began in 1946. Read about how [wars have changed](#).



Photograph: Getty Images

No Shangri-La for China

Pete Hegseth, America's secretary of war, has travelled to Singapore for the Shangri-La Dialogue, an annual gabfest of defence ministers, military commanders and spy chiefs that began on Friday. But his Chinese counterpart, Admiral Dong Jun, will not be there. This is a sign that China's beleaguered military leaders are keeping a low profile. Many have been removed from their posts in recent months [following accusations of corruption](#).

The no-show is a missed opportunity for America and China to talk. Their defence chiefs once spoke every year at the Shangri-La Dialogue. Yet China was never fully comfortable at the event, where its leaders faced difficult questions that they would not be asked back home. In the keynote address, [To Lam](#), Vietnam's recently re-elected president, is expected to call for greater co-operation among middle powers caught between an adversarial America and China.



Photograph: EPA

The widening war in Lebanon

Iran has repeatedly insisted that its shaky ceasefire agreement with America, reached several weeks ago, covers Lebanon. Israel, however, denies this. And its battle with Hizbullah, the Iran-backed militia in Lebanon, is escalating. On Thursday Israel ordered the evacuation of much of southern Lebanon, as it carried out air strikes on the city of Tyre. Hizbullah said it had engaged with Israeli troops at “point-blank range” in a nearby town.

Israeli army officers say their main objective in southern Lebanon is to push Hizbullah’s drone operators farther from the border. So far they have failed. Hizbullah has continued to hit Israeli troops and civilians with drones, defying demands by the Lebanese government that it stop. Meanwhile American-mediated talks to end [the war](#) have been taking place in Washington, DC. Yet they seem to have no effect on what is happening on the ground.

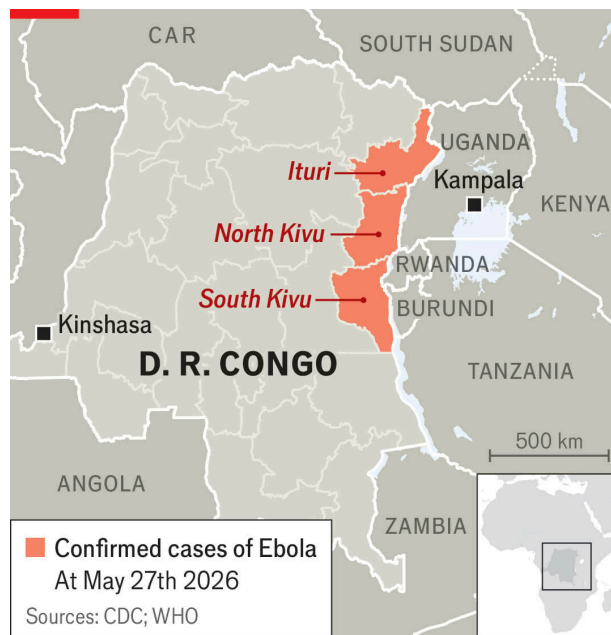


Photograph: EPA

Ebola rips through Congo

The worst [outbreak of Ebola](#) since 2018 is spreading fast. More than 1,000 suspected cases and around 250 suspected deaths have been recorded in the Democratic Republic of Congo. The real tally is almost certainly much higher, because authorities are struggling to identify, test and track patients. Ebola is also reaching other countries. Uganda, which abuts the province at the centre of the outbreak, has confirmed seven cases and closed its border with Congo.

The response has been late and chaotic. That is partly because working in eastern Congo is extremely difficult. The region is poor and full of militias. People have little trust in officials who are marshalling the response. Before the outbreak donors had also cut funding for schemes that tracked Ebola. Those donors are now sending more cash to help health-care workers. Meanwhile scientists are racing to make an experimental vaccine. But that will take, at best, two to three months.





Photograph: AP

Can Hungary clean up its act?

Today Hungary's new prime minister, Peter Magyar, intends to sign an agreement with the EU to thaw frozen funds. The deal will lay out what Hungary must do to [reverse rule-of-law violations](#) which, under Viktor Orban, Mr Magyar's autocratic predecessor, prompted the EU to withhold a total of €18bn (\$21bn)—worth nearly 10% of Hungary's GDP. To get the bulk of that, Hungary must make a substantial number of the necessary changes by the end of August: €10.4bn in post-covid recovery funds will expire otherwise.

Given the sorry state of Hungary's finances, Mr Magyar can ill-afford such an outcome. But most observers agree three months is too little time for meaningful judicial reform. The question, therefore, is whether the European Commission trusts Mr Magyar's government enough to hand over the cash. In 2023 it released similarly frozen funds for Poland quickly, only to see some of the government's reforms blocked by the president, a member of the populist-right opposition.



Photograph: Alamy

When DEET smells like dinner

Dogs can be trained as guides, crows to pick up litter and rats to sniff out landmines. [New research](#), published in the *Journal of Experimental Biology*, reveals that even the seemingly mindless mosquito is capable of learning.

A team of researchers led by Claudio Lazzari, a behavioural physiologist at University of Tours in France, presented mosquitoes with sheep's blood while they were exposed to a breeze, some of which was tainted with DEET. The same mosquitoes were then presented with a pair of researchers' hands: one sprayed with the potent bug-repellent; the other without. Some 60% of the mosquitoes that had previously been exposed to both blood and DEET at the same time immediately flew to the repellent-coated hand.

Dr Lazzari concludes that these insects learned to associate the bug-spray with food, turning a repellent into a lure. There is a good chance that, in the real world, mosquitoes are learning the same thing.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: What is the civilian name of the superhero “The Thing” in the Fantastic Four stories?

Thursday: Which philosopher and economist was born in Trier in 1818 and died in London in 1883?

*Conformity is the jailer of
freedom and the enemy of growth.*

John F. Kennedy